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The Indian entertainment industry looks good these days, and it's all thanks to some very special effects...

Meera Vankipuram

When we heard that Salman Khan battles six Akshay Kumars in David Dhawan's *Mujhse Shaadi Karogi* for the hand of Priyanka Chopra, we thought of many doubles with bad wigs and mismatching body sizes. However, we were in for a pleasant surprise when we saw the movie—there actually were six

Akshay Kumars! Special effects (SFX) in Bollywood movies are hitting new heights.

Directors are now looking for that something extra to make their movies a tad more special—just a good soundtrack doesn't cut it anymore in India. It's not just Bollywood either: whether it's TV serials, sports programmes, music videos, or animation films, we expect so much more in terms of visual appeal. If the Wachowski brothers can do it for *The Matrix Trilogy*, why can't we? Dhawan's flick has nowhere close to the amazing SFX that thrilled us in the *Matrix*, but it's a start! Other movies such as *Rudraksh*—where the SFX is more comic relief than awe-inspiring—could have used some professional SFX help.

Indian cinema and production houses are beginning to adopt advanced SFX techniques such as Motion Capture and Motion Control—a combination of which made Neo appear super-human in the *Matrix*.

John Gaeta, visual effects supervisor of *The Matrix Trilogy*, used a technique called 'Bullet Time'—inspired by the popular Japanese animation style 'anime'. He also coined the term 'Virtual Cinematography'—the process of translating the Bullet Time technique on to the big screen. Virtual Cinematography helped depict action-packed, surreal scenes in slow-motion, as seen by a camera moving at regular speed. The result was super-human feats, accomplished at a level of realism never seen before. Motion Capture (MoCap) helped create these virtual super-humans.

Inside MoCap

MoCap is a process that uses subjects in special suits that contain several 'data points'. Data (an action sequence or movement) is transmitted to the computers using wired or wireless technology, and cameras. Textures can be added to create realistic animated imagery.

The subject, whose motion is cap-

